

How to Get Better Results from Experts on Your Team

****Quick Bridge:**** Technical leaders often get worse results from domain experts. Not because they are wrong about the solution. Because they lead with it. Here is the shift that changes what you get back from every expert you work with.

I had an engineer friend who owned a Mini Cooper. We both used the same dealership. I always came away happy with the service. He complained about that place every time he went.

One afternoon we both needed service and ended up at the dealer at the same time. I watched what happened at the counter.

He had done his homework. He had read the forums, checked the common issues, formed a diagnosis. When he got to the service advisor, he explained what was wrong, described how it needed to be fixed, and mentioned how long the job should take.

The service advisor knew more about Mini Coopers than my friend ever would. Getting instructions from a customer who had done his own research clearly frustrated him. My friend got mediocre service and a bill that did not match what he expected.

I had done the exact same research. Same forums. Same hypothesis. But when I got to the counter, I said: "Hey, it is broken. Will you figure out what is wrong with it?"

He diagnosed it. Told me what he found. And because I had done my research, I could follow the explanation and verify it made sense. I left satisfied.

We walked into the same building with the same information. The results were completely different.

The difference was not the research. The difference was what we did with it.

He described a solution. I described a problem.

Those are not the same thing.

****When you describe a solution, you take over someone else's job.**** You have done the thinking, arrived at an answer, and now you want the expert to execute it. Their judgment, their experience, and their ownership of the outcome all get replaced by your instructions.

When you describe a problem, you give the expert what they actually need to do their job. They apply their judgment. They own the result. And they often find something you would have missed, because they know things you do not.

This distinction sounds simple. It is almost never practiced.

Here is what it looks like at work.

A game engineer noticed the project was running behind. She needed more time. She went to the project manager and said: "You need to move the date by two weeks because we are late."

The project manager pushed back and started asking questions. The engineer felt like she was not being taken seriously. The conversation turned into a standoff.

From the PM's side: her job is to protect the timeline and manage the commitments made downstream. When someone walks in and says "move the date," she has to understand why, what it affects, and whether there are other options.

She is not being difficult. She is doing her job. The engineer just walked into her domain and issued a directive.

Here is what would have worked instead.

"Things are running behind, and I need two more weeks to get back on track. That estimate does not include any additional scope that might arrive before we are done."

Same facts. Completely different framing.

Now the PM has what she needs. She understands the situation, knows the constraint, and can decide how to handle it. The engineer gets what she needs because she came with information, not a demand.

The distinction is sequence. Problem first. Let the expert respond. Then you decide what to do with what comes back.

Technically strong leaders fall into this more than anyone.

They get hired because they can diagnose fast and build solutions quickly. That skill is genuinely valuable. It is also exactly what makes this situation hard.

When you are the sharpest technical thinker in the room, you often arrive at the answer before anyone else does. Once you have it, handing it over feels efficient. Why describe the problem when you already know what needs to happen?

There is also something that can feel exposing about leading with "here is the problem." It can feel like admitting uncertainty. It is not. It is what actually makes you effective at this level.

Because the person you are talking to is an expert in their domain. When you skip the problem and hand them the solution, you have made their expertise irrelevant. They execute your instructions instead of applying their judgment. You get compliance. You do not get their best work.

****The most effective leaders I have seen give far less direction than most people expect.**** Not because they do not have opinions. Because they understand that the expert in the room is often not them.

[object Object]

Describe what needs to be solved, not how to solve it.

With a service advisor: "It makes a clicking noise when I brake. Can you figure out what is causing it?" Not a list of your research findings and recommended repairs.

With a project manager: "We are behind by two weeks. Here is the breakdown. I wanted you to have this." Not: "Move the date."

With a technical contributor: "This feature breaks when users refresh mid-session. It needs to work reliably before launch." Not a diagram showing exactly how to implement the fix.

You can still do your research and form a hypothesis. Lead with the problem. Let the expert respond. Then bring your research to check what comes back.

Same information in all three cases. The framing is what changes everything.

When people feel over-directed, they stop bringing their full thinking to the problem. They execute instructions. They stop owning outcomes.

****There is a difference between a team that thinks and a team that complies.**** A compliant team does what it is told. A team that thinks solves problems you did not know to ask about.

The leaders who get the best work from experts have learned to sit with the discomfort of not giving the answer. They bring the problem. They trust the expert. They verify the result.

That is not passivity. That is leverage.

Before your next conversation with someone whose expertise is not yours, write down what you are about to say. Ask yourself: am I describing a problem or giving a solution?

If you are giving a solution, rewrite it as a problem statement. See what comes back.

Have you ever worked for a leader who already had the answer before the conversation started? What did that do to how you showed up?

You are great at the work. Let us make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help getting better results from the people around you, consider reaching out.

<https://www.jessestaffordcoaching.com>

****Tags:**** Leadership, Management, Engineering Management, Career Advice, Professional Development

****Feature image prompt (Bing DALL-E, under 380 chars):**** Two professionals in conversation, one describing a problem at a service counter, the other listening with expertise, modern professional setting, warm natural lighting, realistic photography style, clean uncluttered composition, focus on attentive listening